- As of the end of January, most areas in the region are classified as Stressed (IPC Phase 2) thanks to seasonal factors such as the *postrera* harvest at the end of 2023, which increased food reserves in producer households and lowered prices of basic grains, and the increased incomes in households involved in trade, tourism, and agricultural labor. However, the magnitude of the seasonal improvement is less than usual due to the agricultural damages and losses throughout 2023 due to El Niño driven erratic weather patterns and the persistence of well above-average prices. To meet food needs, most poor rural households in the region have resorted to negative coping strategies, such as adjusting diet quality. However, areas in the Dry Corridor and northern Honduras constitute pockets of the population experiencing Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes. The poorest agricultural households in these areas experienced crop failure during 2023, resulting in a lack of reserves for the subsequent months. This caused them to continue to rely on coping strategies such as indebtedness, the sale of household goods, and modifications to the amount of food consumed to meet food needs.

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- From February through May, due to agricultural losses in 2023, the rural poor households in the areas of the Dry Corridor and northern Honduras will see a progressive deterioration in food access as prices of basic grains begin to rise while income opportunities fall, setting up the lean season (up to two months) early transitioning Honduras to Crisis (IPC Phase 3). Households in these areas of Honduras will resort to unsustainable coping strategies to meet their food needs, such as limiting the number of meals consumed and the quantity of food. In contrast, El Salvador and Nicaragua suffered fewer negative impacts on agricultural production and will remain classified as Stressed (IPC Phase 2) through May, with poor households continuing to resort to changes in dietary quality to meet their food needs. In Nicaragua, in particular, the *apante* bean harvest is expected to have average results, which is important for the overall regional bean supply. However, this will not be enough to offset several years of shocks that have continued to diminish the regional supply since 2019. Prices of basic grains are projected to persist above the five-year average, especially in the case of red beans which report increases of up to 76 percent and continue to limit household purchasing power.

- A seasonal decrease in rainfall accumulations in December, combined with the persistence of abnormally above-average temperatures, negatively impacted the yields of *postrera* crops for small producers in the Dry Corridor areas of Honduras and, to a lesser extent, El Salvador. The *apante*/late *postrera* cycle is currently underway in Nicaragua and in areas of northern Honduras. Sufficient and timely rainfall accumulations for crop development forecast favorable results for the upcoming harvest, despite